You can define features quite a bit ahead of time, but you only want to start creating stories for a feature when you get closer to actually implementing the feature.

It's important to remember that user stories are essentially planning artifacts. They're a great way to organize the work you need to do to deliver a feature, but the end user doesn't really care how you organize things to get the feature out the door, as long as it gets delivered. Future developers are more interested in what the application currently does than how you went about building it.

Once the feature has been implemented, the user stories can be discarded. The description of the features (see section 4.1.1) is generally more effective at describing what the application does. The examples you use to illustrate the features and stories (see section 4.2) do a great job of illustrating how the software actually works, as do the automated acceptance criteria that you'll write later on in this book.

4.1.5 Epics are really big user stories

Many teams, especially ones that use Scrum, use the term "epic" to refer to a very large user story that will eventually be broken down into smaller stories. There's no magic definition for what makes a story *epic*, but if a story turns out to be so big that it needs several sprints to complete, it would typically be broken up into a number of smaller, more manageable user stories.

There are a few obvious similarities between the definition of *features* in section 4.1.1 and the way I'm describing epics. Both may need to be broken down into a number of smaller stories, and both can span several iterations. Epics, like features and stories, are focused on delivering business value to the users in some form. But epics, like stories, are primarily useful for project planning.

We won't use epics much in the rest of this book, but let's see how an epic would fit in with the requirements organization we've been looking at so far. If your idea of an epic is simply a very large user story that can be broken down into smaller user stories, then epics would fit under features, or possibly be synonymous with features (see figure 4.12).

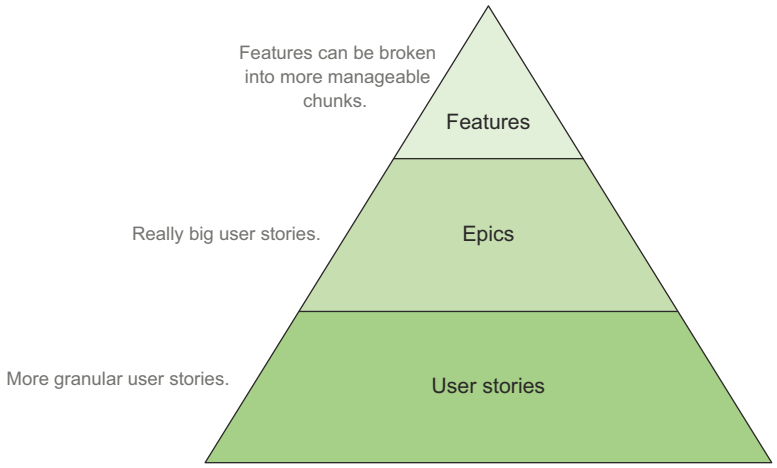


Figure 4.12 Some teams simply define epics as very large user stories.